

DC-Link Voltage Scaling to 1.2 kV for Heavy-Duty EVs: System-Level Assessment with Experimental Validation of SiC Traction Inverter

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Research leading to these results has received funding from the EU CHIPS Joint Undertaking under grant agreement n° 101007326 (project PowerizeD) and from the (Swedish) partner national funding authority Vinnova. Funding for this research has also been received from the Swedish Energy Agency under grant agreement P2022-00956 through the HEMIZERO project.

ABSTRACT The electrification of heavy-duty vehicles (HDVs) is essential for achieving zero-emission freight transport. Conventional 400–800 V powertrains face limitations in supporting megawatt-level fast charging and high continuous power due to excessive current, cable losses, and thermal stress. Recent advances in high voltage (i.e., 1.7 kV, 2 kV, 3.3 kV) silicon-carbide (SiC) power modules and charging standards such as the Megawatt Charging System (MCS, up to 1250 V) have enabled a new generation of 1.2 kV dc-link architectures for HDVs. This paper presents a comprehensive system-level evaluation of increasing the dc-link voltage from 800 V to 1.2 kV, covering the battery, inverter, and motor subsystems. The battery/charging and motor-level results are presented as analytical first-order assessments, whereas the inverter-level loss-modelling methodology is experimentally validated on a 250 kW, 1.2 kV dc-link SiC prototype. A virtual-prototyping framework is used to quantify inverter losses, thermal behavior, and volume trade-offs, and the switching frequency is optimized by jointly considering inverter and motor harmonic losses. Experimental results show that the analytical models predict measured inverter losses within approximately 10% over the tested operating range. Under the representative charging assumptions adopted in this study, 1.2 kV dc-link voltage enables either an ~56% reduction in cable conduction losses or an ~33% reduction in cable mass, while the prototype achieves an efficiency of ~99.12%, a specific power density of 49.4 kW/L, and a bounding-box-based volumetric power density of 20.83 kW/L. The results provide system-level assessment and experimentally supported inverter-level design guidance for 1.2 kV HDV powertrains.

INDEX TERMS High-voltage powertrain, traction inverter, heavy-duty electric vehicle, fast charging, dc-link voltage, insulation design, and harmonic losses.

I. INTRODUCTION

Electrification of heavy-duty vehicles (HDVs) is one of the most effective strategies to reduce transport-related CO₂ emissions and to meet international climate goals such as those set by the Paris Agreement [1]. Therefore, in recent years, the automotive industry has accelerated the development of fully electric trucks to support the transition toward zero-emission heavy-duty transport [2].

Conventional HDV platforms typically operate with battery voltages up to 800 V [2], [3]. However, the increasing power demand of long-haul applications and the need for shorter charging times have exposed the limitations of these voltage levels [4], [5]. The high currents required at 800 V

cause excessive cable heating, increased conductor mass, and significant I^2R losses, which reduce overall efficiency and require complex cooling solutions for the charging infrastructure [5]. Moreover, at the inverter and motor levels, these high currents constrain both power density and thermal design margins [6]. To overcome these issues, higher-voltage architectures are being considered for next-generation HDVs, enabled by the availability of high-voltage SiC power modules (1.7–2.0 kV classes) and improved insulation technologies.

The development of new charging standards has further supported this transition. While the Combined Charging System (CCS) has become the de facto interface for commercial vehicles, the emerging Megawatt Charging System (MCS)

supports voltages up to 1250 V and charging powers exceeding 1 MW [7]. Such capabilities are essential to satisfy regulatory requirements such as EU Regulation, which mandates that professional drivers take a minimum 45-minute break after every 4.5 hours of driving [8]. This rule implies that a heavy-duty vehicle must be fully recharged within 45 minutes to maintain operational flexibility.

At the powertrain level, increasing the dc-link voltage reduces conduction losses and current stress across the drivetrain, thereby enabling higher efficiency and more compact designs [5], [9]. Moreover, achieving a system-level perspective requires a comprehensive understanding that jointly considers the battery, inverter, and traction motor, rather than treating each subsystem in isolation. Despite recent progress, a unified framework that jointly quantifies these multi-domain interactions across voltage levels, together with experimental validation of inverter-level design methodology at 1.2 kV, is still limited.

A. RESEARCH GAP

Most existing studies focus on individual drivetrain subsystems such as the inverter [10], [11], [12], the motor [13], [14], [15], or the battery and charging system [16], [17], [18], [19], without assessing the complete drivetrain when the dc-link voltage is increased. Recent works have reviewed the transition from 400 V to 800 V architectures and analyzed their system-level benefits and implementation challenges for passenger electric vehicles [20], [5]. However, these analyses remain focused on light-duty applications, while the implications of further increasing the voltage beyond 1 kV in heavy-duty drivetrains have yet to be systematically investigated.

To address this gap, this paper introduces a high-voltage HDV assessment framework that integrates battery/charging behavior, inverter loss and volume trade-offs, and motor harmonic-loss considerations. In addition, the inverter-level analytical methodology is experimentally assessed using a 250 kW, 1.2 kV dc-link SiC prototype, thereby linking system-level comparison with prototype-grounded inverter design.

B. RESEARCH OBJECTIVE AND CONTRIBUTIONS

The objective of this paper is to quantify how increasing the dc-link voltage influences the charging performance, efficiency, power density, and harmonic losses of the complete electric drivetrain. The investigation encompasses the battery and charging system, traction inverter, and motor subsystem, as illustrated in Fig. 1.

The main contributions of this work are summarized as follows:

- 1) **Framework-level charging assessment:** Analytical comparison of 800 V and 1.2 kV architectures under representative megawatt-charging conditions, quantifying charging current, cable-loss scaling, and cable-mass trends.
- 2) **Framework-level inverter benchmark:** Equal-power, equal-loss comparison of two 250 kW SiC traction in-

verters using a virtual-prototyping framework to assess conduction losses, switching losses, dc-link capacitor requirements, cooling demand, and resulting power-density trends.

- 3) **Framework-level motor-loss interpretation:** Impedance-based evaluation of motor harmonic losses under winding reconnection, clarifying under which assumptions the additional PWM-related loss contribution is expected to remain of similar magnitude when scaling the dc-link voltage.
- 4) **Holistic switching-frequency selection:** Combined consideration of inverter losses and motor harmonic losses for the selected 1.2 kV design case in order to identify an efficiency-maximizing switching-frequency.
- 5) **Experimental validation:** Experimental assessment of the analytical inverter loss model and realized component volumes on a 250 kW, 1.2 kV SiC prototype inverter.

It is important to distinguish the scope of the different parts of this work. The battery/charging comparison is presented as a first-order analytical scaling study, the 800 V versus 1.2 kV inverter comparison is performed using a virtual-prototyping framework, and the motor harmonic-loss analysis is based on an impedance-derived loss-factor approach under stated assumptions. Experimental validation is performed for the selected 1.2 kV inverter case.

II. SYSTEM REQUIREMENTS AND DESIGN BASIS

To provide a consistent basis for comparison, two dc-link voltage levels (800 V and 1.2 kV) are selected as representative of HDV powertrains. These values reflect the ongoing transition from existing 800 V platforms toward next-generation 1.2 kV architectures that support megawatt-class charging and improved drivetrain efficiency. Both systems are rated at 250 kW traction power. The inverters employ silicon-carbide (SiC) power modules with comparable chip technology, thermal characteristics, and cooling capability to ensure a fair comparison across voltage levels. Identical modulation indices and switching strategies are applied in both cases to maintain consistent operating conditions. The 800 V configuration utilizes 1.2 kV SiC devices, whereas the 1.2 kV setup adopts 2.0 kV modules.

Table 1 summarizes the design parameters used as fixed inputs for the subsequent analyses, including loss modeling, inverter volume estimation, and motor harmonic-loss evaluation. The comparison adopted in this paper is based on equal output power and comparable thermal feasibility, which enables the effect of dc-link voltage scaling on current stress, passive-component sizing, and power density to be isolated. It is noted that alternative benchmarking philosophies, such as equal cost, equal package count, or equal volume, may lead to different absolute design spaces.

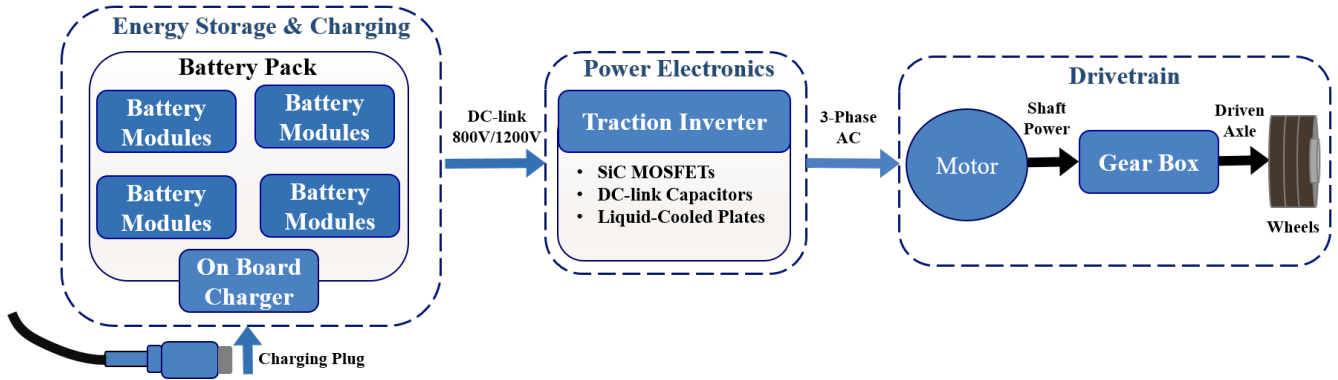


FIGURE 1. Schematic of the HDV traction system with battery, traction inverter, motor, and gearbox driving the axle.

TABLE 1. System Requirements and Design Parameters

Parameter	800 V	1.2 kV
Rated power, P_{out} [kW]	250	250
Dc-link voltage, U_{dc} [V]	800	1200
Phase Current, I_{ph} [A]	294	196
Input current, I_{in} [A]	315	208
Power factor, p_f	0.9-1	0.9-1
Switching frequency, f_{sw} [kHz]	10–20	10–20
Semiconductor technology	1.2 kV SiC	2.0 kV SiC
Cooling method	Liquid	Liquid

III. ANALYSIS OF BATTERY AND CHARGING SYSTEM

A. BATTERY PACK CONFIGURATION

The total energy stored in a traction battery is given by

$$E_{pack} = N_s N_p V_{cell} Q_{cell}, \quad (1)$$

where N_s and N_p represent the numbers of cells in series and parallel, V_{cell} is the nominal cell voltage, and Q_{cell} is the single-cell capacity. Increasing the dc-link voltage from 800 V to 1.2 kV raises the series cell count while reducing parallel branches, preserving approximately the same total energy capacity:

$$E_{pack,800V} \approx E_{pack,1200V}. \quad (2)$$

The resulting higher voltage lowers pack current, thereby reducing conduction losses in busbars and interconnects. At these elevated voltage levels, the design focus shifts toward insulation coordination between modules, which can be ensured through encapsulated housings, reinforced dielectric materials, and sufficient creepage and clearance distances [21]. These practices enable reliable operation under increased electric field stress across the battery pack.

The final battery-pack design also depends on cell voltage limits, thermal layout, balancing strategy, insulation coordination, and fault-management requirements, which are outside the present first-order comparison.

B. FAST-CHARGING PERFORMANCE

The instantaneous charging current is defined as

$$I_{ch} = \frac{P_{ch}}{\eta_{ch} U_{dc}}, \quad (3)$$

where P_{ch} denotes the charging power, η_{ch} the charging efficiency, and U_{dc} the dc-link voltage. The corresponding cable conduction loss is

$$P_{loss} = I_{ch}^2 R_{cable}, \quad (4)$$

with R_{cable} representing the total resistance of the cable and connectors. For a constant charging power, increasing U_{dc} reduces the current and therefore the conduction losses according to

$$\frac{P_{loss,2}}{P_{loss,1}} = \left(\frac{U_{dc,1}}{U_{dc,2}} \right)^2, \quad (5)$$

indicating that an increase from 800 V to 1.2 kV lowers resistive losses to about 44% of their former value when the same conductor area is maintained.

Conversely, when the maximum cable current is fixed, the achievable charging power scales linearly with voltage:

$$P_{ch,max} = \eta_{ch} U_{dc} I_{max}. \quad (6)$$

Hence, from a voltage-current scaling perspective and neglecting battery acceptance limits and charging-power tapering, a 1.2 kV system can deliver roughly 50% higher charging power than an 800 V counterpart under identical current limits. The corresponding idealized constant-power charging time indicates the potential for shorter charging duration at the higher DC-link voltage. This improvement can support the possibility of complete charging within the 45-minute rest period, subject to battery acceptance capability, thermal limits, and charging-profile constraints [8].

C. THERMAL AND MECHANICAL CONSIDERATIONS

Building on the reduced charging current (for the same charging power), the associated losses are reduced, and the thermal stress on cables and connectors is alleviated. The required conductor cross-section can be approximated as

$$A = \frac{I_{ch}}{J_{max}}, \quad (7)$$

where J_{max} is the permissible current density. Since resistive heating scales with the square of the current ($P_{loss} \propto I^2$), the decrease in current at higher dc-link voltage reduces thermal

dissipation to about 45% of its previous level. This enables the use of cables with smaller cross-section and lower mass, typically decreasing total cable weight by 33%. The reduced thermal load further simplifies cooling requirements and improves both operational safety and handling ergonomics during high-power charging.

D. QUANTITATIVE COMPARISON (1 MW TARGET)

Table 2 summarizes key parameters for 800 V and 1.2 kV systems when delivering 1 MW charging power, and additionally compares the 800 V case operated at the same current as the 1.2 kV system ($I_{ch} = 877$ A). All cases assume $\eta_{ch} = 0.95$ and a 600 kWh traction battery.

TABLE 2. Comparison of 800 V and 1.2 kV Systems for 1 MW Charging ($E_{pack} = 600$ kWh, $\eta_{ch} = 0.95$)

Parameter	800 V (1 MW)	1.2 kV (1 MW)	800 V (877 A)
U_{dc} [V]	800	1200	800
I_{ch} [A]	1316	877	877
P_{ch} [kW]	1000	1000	~670
I^2R loss ratio	1.00	0.44	0.44
t_{ch} (600 kWh) [min]	36	36	~54
Cable mass trend	higher	↓33%	↓33%
MCS compliance	partial	full	partial

The values in Table 2 are first-order estimates based on constant charging power, fixed charging efficiency, and representative cable-current assumptions; they do not represent a full battery charging profile including voltage-dependent power tapering, thermal limits, or state-of-charge constraints.

Raising the dc-link voltage from 800 V to 1.2 kV lowers the charging current by about one-third for the same charging power and correspondingly reduces the associated I^2R losses by more than half under identical cable-resistance assumptions. When the current is instead held constant at 877 A, the 800 V system delivers only about two-thirds of the power of the 1.2 kV system, extending the idealized full-charge duration from about 36 min to about 54 min. These results indicate the practical charging advantage of the higher dc-link voltage under the representative assumptions considered here.

IV. INVERTER BENCHMARK: VIRTUAL-PROTOTYPING FRAMEWORK

This section compares two 2-level, 3-phase (2L-3Ph) SiC traction inverters, shown in Fig. 2, that differ only in dc-link voltage level (800 V and 1.2 kV). The comparison is structured to isolate the effect of dc-link voltage scaling under equal-power and equal-loss benchmarking assumptions.

Both configurations employ identical mechanical layouts, power-module packages, control hardware, and liquid-cooling arrangements. The comparison isolates the impact of dc-link voltage scaling on semiconductor losses, passive-component requirements, and overall power density under consistent design and thermal constraints.

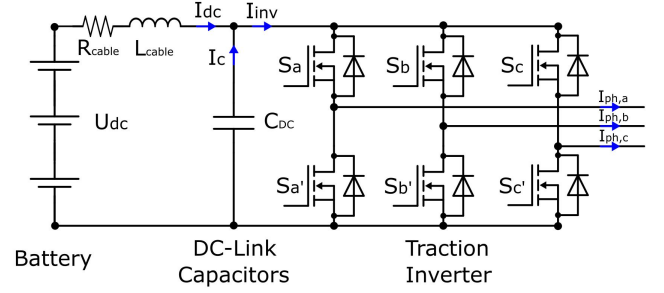


FIGURE 2. Two-level three-phase inverter schematic including dc-link capacitor and cable parasitics.

A. ASSUMPTIONS AND COMPARISON METHODOLOGY

To ensure a fair and consistent comparison between the 800 V and 1.2 kV inverters, the following assumptions are applied:

- Identical module footprint (i.e., 62 mm power module) and mechanical integration for both voltage levels.
- Equal total semiconductor losses at the rated operating point, verified through design-space exploration to maintain comparable cooling requirements.
- Maximum junction temperature limited to a specific value (i.e., $T_j \leq 125^\circ\text{C}$) to ensure thermal feasibility.
- Carrier-based sinusoidal PWM with balanced three-phase currents for dc-link current ripple assessment.
- Similar safety margins for device ratings to account for overshoot and reliability considerations.

Equal-loss benchmarking was selected because it yields comparable thermal loading and cooling demand for the compared designs, thereby allowing the influence of dc-link voltage on current stress, passive components sizing, and resulting power density to be more clearly isolated.

B. CURRENT SCALING

For equal output power, the RMS phase current scales inversely with the dc-link voltage:

$$I_{1200} = I_{800} \frac{800}{1200}. \quad (8)$$

Accordingly, the 1.2 kV inverter operates at a proportionally lower current magnitude. However, the overall loss reduction is not directly proportional to the current decrease. Higher-voltage SiC devices employ thicker drift regions, which increase the specific on-resistance ($R_{DS(on)}$ per unit area) and partially offset the expected conduction-loss improvement. Moreover, switching losses tend to rise with device voltage class due to higher output capacitance and longer voltage-transition durations, especially at comparable gate-drive and dv/dt conditions. Therefore, both conduction and switching loss characteristics must be jointly evaluated to accurately quantify the net efficiency gain achievable through dc-link voltage scaling.

C. MODELING FRAMEWORK

A virtual-prototyping framework is established to evaluate inverter performance independently of any specific com-

mercial module. Each design point is characterized by the switching frequency (f_{sw}), active die area (A_{die}), and device voltage class (U_b). Semiconductor losses are calculated using technology-specific figures of merit (FOMs) parameters, while thermal feasibility is ensured by maintaining the junction temperature below its specified limit. The required dc-link capacitance and corresponding volume are derived from the dc-link ripple current characteristics. Finally, the total inverter volume and specific power density are obtained by assembling the volumes of the power modules, dc-link capacitors, and cooling system.

D. SEMICONDUCTOR LOSS MODELING

Semiconductor losses consist of conduction and switching components. The conduction loss per device is given by

$$P_c = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_{\theta_{C1}}^{\theta_{C2}} r_{ds} i_{ds}^2(\theta) D(\theta) d\theta, \quad (9)$$

where $D(\theta)$ is the duty ratio, $i_{ds}(\theta)$ the instantaneous device current, θ_{C1} to θ_{C2} is conduction angle and r_{ds} is the on-state resistance, which can be estimated as

$$r_{ds} = \frac{k_R U_B^{\alpha_r}}{A_{die}}. \quad (10)$$

where A_{die} is active die area, k_R , and α_r are technology-dependent coefficients, and U_B is the blocking voltage. This formulation captures the duty-cycle-weighted RMS conduction loss over one electrical period. In the conduction loss calculation, reverse conduction and body diode are neglected. These simplifications introduce opposing errors during reverse conduction and dead-time intervals that partially compensate each other [22], [23].

Switching losses can be split into two components: the zero-current term associated with the output capacitance and the overlap term related to dv/dt and di/dt during turn-on and turn-off transitions. The zero-current switching energy is approximated as

$$E_{sw,ZCS} = k_c U_b^{\alpha_c} A_{die} U_{dc}^2, \quad (11)$$

where k_c , and α_c are technology-dependent coefficients, U_{dc} is the switching voltage that is the same as the dc-link voltage in a 2-level inverter.

The overlap energy is expressed as

$$E_{sw,overlap} = \left(\frac{U_{dc} I_{sw}^2}{2 (di/dt)_{on}} + \frac{U_{dc}^2 I_{sw}}{2 (dv/dt)_{on}} \right) + \left(\frac{U_{dc} I_{sw}^2}{2 (di/dt)_{off}} + \frac{U_{dc}^2 I_{sw}}{2 (dv/dt)_{off}} \right), \quad (12)$$

where I_{sw} is the quasi-constant value of the switch current, dv/dt is the voltage slew rate, and di/dt is the current slew rate. Further, the overlap energy can be approximated by a low-order polynomial as

$$E_{sw,overlap}(I_{sw}, U_{dc}) \approx \alpha_1(U_{dc}) |I_{sw}| + \alpha_2(U_{dc}) I_{sw}^2. \quad (13)$$

where the coefficients α_1 and α_2 depend on the switching voltage, and voltage and current slew rates. Using (12) and (13), the coefficients can be explicitly derived as

$$\alpha_1(U_{dc}) = \frac{U_{dc}^2}{2} \left[\frac{1}{(dv/dt)_{on}} + \frac{1}{(dv/dt)_{off}} \right], \quad (14)$$

$$\alpha_2(U_{dc}) = \frac{U_{dc}}{2} \left[\frac{1}{(di/dt)_{on}} + \frac{1}{(di/dt)_{off}} \right].$$

These relations show that slower voltage and current transitions (lower dv/dt and di/dt) increase both coefficients, resulting in higher switching losses, while faster transitions reduce α_1 and α_2 but worsen electromagnetic interference (EMI) and common-mode voltage stress. In this paper, the maximum values of dv/dt and di/dt are selected as 10 kV/ μ s and 10 kA/ μ s, respectively, and the coefficients α_1 and α_2 are estimated based on these limits. Alternatively, the coefficients α_1 and α_2 can be identified and validated experimentally through double-pulse measurements by fitting the measured $E_{sw,overlap}(I_{sw})$ characteristics to (13) after subtracting the zero-current energy term given in (11).

Consequently, the total switching losses are obtained as

$$P_{sw} = \frac{f_{sw}}{2\pi} \int_{\theta_{SW1}}^{\theta_{SW2}} (E_{sw,ZCS} + E_{sw,overlap}) d\theta. \quad (15)$$

where θ_{SW1} to θ_{SW2} is switching angle.

The figure-of-merit and overlap-loss parameters for SiC MOSFETs used in this paper are summarized in Table 3.

TABLE 3. Figure-of-Merit Parameters [24] and Overlap-Loss Coefficients for SiC MOSFETs.

Parameter	Value	Unit
k_r	7.2×10^{-3}	$m\Omega mm^2 V^{-1.6}$
α_r	1.6	—
k_c	1.6×10^4	$pF mm^{-2} V$
α_c	—1	—
$\alpha_1(1200)$	144	$\mu J / A$
$\alpha_2(1200)$	120	nJ / A^2
$\alpha_1(800)$	64	$\mu J / A$
$\alpha_2(800)$	80	nJ / A^2

E. IMPLEMENTATION OF THE LOSS MODELING ALGORITHM IN A TWO-LEVEL INVERTER

The conduction and switching intervals of the semiconductor devices are used to calculate the inverter losses according to (9) and (15). These intervals depend on the inverter topology and modulation scheme [23]. As summarized in Table 4, the conduction angles, duty ratios, and switching angles for each switch in a single inverter leg are defined for a positive half-cycle of the phase current.

F. DEVICE RATING AND DIE-AREA OPTIMIZATION

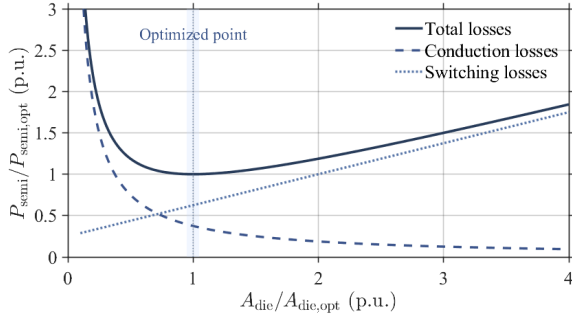
Device voltage ratings are selected with safety factors of 1.5 and 1.66 to account for voltage overshoot, parasitic effects, and reliability margins [25], resulting in 1.2 kV devices for the 800 V system and 2.0 kV devices for the 1.2 kV system. Within a fixed package, the active die area is optimized to

TABLE 4. Conduction and Switching Angles for Two-Level Inverters.

Switch	Conduction Angle	Duty ratio	Switching Angle
Upper	ϕ to $\pi + \phi$	$\frac{1+m_a \cdot \sin(\theta)}{2}$	ϕ to $\pi + \phi$
Lower*	ϕ to $\pi + \phi$	$\frac{1-m_a \cdot \sin(\theta)}{2}$	-

* means that the switch is in reverse conduction.

balance conduction and switching losses at a given switching frequency f_{sw} and voltage slew rate dv/dt . As illustrated in Fig. 3, reducing the die area increases the on-state resistance r_{ds} and associated conduction losses, whereas enlarging the die area increases switching losses due to higher output capacitance.

**FIGURE 3. Conduction, switching, and total losses versus active die area at fixed f_{sw} and dv/dt . The optimal A_{die} minimizes total losses.**

The intersection of these opposing trends defines the optimal die area ($A_{die,opt}$), corresponding to maximum efficiency while maintaining the junction temperature (T_j) constraint.

G. THERMAL AND COOLING-SYSTEM ESTIMATION

A simplified thermal network is adopted, including the junction-to-case, case-to-cold-plate, and cold-plate-to-ambient thermal resistances. First, the junction-to-case thermal resistance decreases with increasing die area and is expressed as

$$R_{jc} = \frac{r_{th-die}}{A_{die}}, \quad (16)$$

where r_{th-die} is the die-specific thermal resistance coefficient. Second, the case-to-cold-plate thermal resistance is assumed to be determined by the device package and mounting conditions. Third, the required case-to-ambient thermal resistance to maintain the junction temperature constraint (i.e., $T_j \leq 125^\circ\text{C}$) is given by

$$R_{ca} = \frac{T_j - T_a}{P_{loss}} - (R_{jc-eq} + R_{cc-eq}), \quad (17)$$

where T_a is the ambient temperature, P_{loss} is the total semiconductor power loss, and R_{jc-eq} and R_{cc-eq} denote the equivalent junction-to-case and case-to-cold-plate thermal resistances, respectively.

Finally, the required cold-plate volume is estimated using the cooling-system performance index (CSPI) [26] as

$$V_h = \frac{1}{R_{ca} \cdot \text{CSPI}}. \quad (18)$$

The adopted cooling-volume estimate is intended for comparative design screening rather than detailed thermo-fluid optimization of the cold-plate geometry and flow path.

H. DC-LINK CAPACITANCE ESTIMATION

Assuming sinusoidal phase currents, the instantaneous dc-link capacitor current is expressed as

$$I_C(t) = \sum_{n=1}^{N_{ph}} S_n(t) I_n(t), \quad (19)$$

where $S_n(t)$ denotes the switching functions represented by a double Fourier expansion [27]. The minimum required dc-link capacitance for a specified voltage ripple ΔV^{pp} is calculated as

$$C_{bus} \geq \frac{\max\left(\int_0^{T_s} (I_C - I_{dc}) dt\right) - \min\left(\int_0^{T_s} (I_C - I_{dc}) dt\right)}{\Delta V^{pp}}. \quad (20)$$

At constant power, increasing the dc-link voltage proportionally reduces the capacitor ripple current, thereby lowering the required capacitance; however, the capacitor volume per capacitance increases with dc-link voltage.

The dc-link capacitor sizing is therefore used here as a comparative design metric based on ripple-related requirements, whereas detailed thermal ripple constraints, ESR-dependent heating, and lifetime considerations are excluded.

I. DESIGN-POINT SELECTION AND EFFICIENCY MAPPING

A parametric sweep across switching frequency and die area is performed for both voltage levels. Fig. 4 shows the switching-loss and on-state-resistance characteristics, along with the corresponding efficiency distribution over the design space. The selected designs, achieving comparable total losses (at $\eta \approx 99.2\%$), are summarized in Table 5.

TABLE 5. Switching Frequencies and Die Areas of the Selected Operating Points.

Inverter	f_{sw} (kHz)	A_{die} (mm ²)	η (%)
800 V	14	300	99.2
1.2 kV	10	300	99.2

In addition to semiconductor-loss optimization, the dc-link capacitance requirements are evaluated as a function of switching frequency and voltage level. As shown in Fig. 5.a, increasing f_{sw} decreases the required capacitance since the charge ripple per switching period becomes smaller. Higher dc-link voltage levels further reduce ripple current, lowering capacitance demand for a given voltage ripple specification. To quantify the size impact, Fig. 5.b converts the capacitance into estimated capacitor volume based on representative volumetric energy densities. The 1.2 kV design achieves roughly a 20% reduction in total capacitor volume compared with the 800 V system, illustrating a power-density benefit of higher dc-link operation.

These selected points serve as representative equal-loss benchmark designs. Section VI subsequently refines the

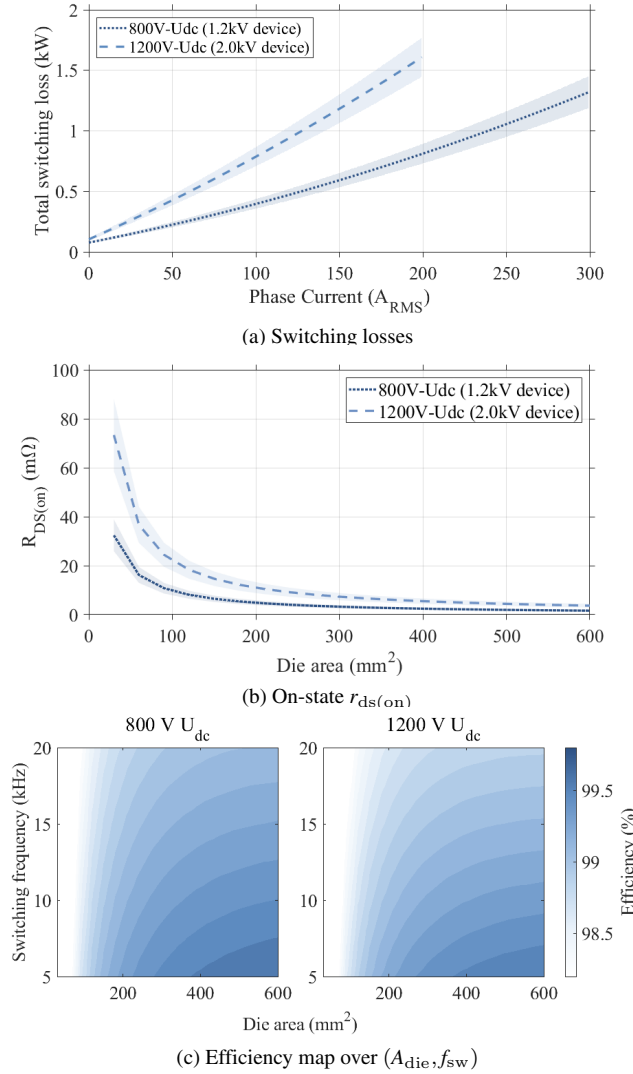


FIGURE 4. Benchmark results at rated conditions: (a) switching losses at 10 kHz, (b) on-state resistance, (c) efficiency variation over die area and switching frequency.

switching-frequency choice for the selected 1.2 kV design by explicitly incorporating the trade-off between inverter and motor harmonic losses.

J. THERMAL PARAMETERS AND VOLUME OF COOLING SYSTEM

Using $r_{th,die} = 2.5 \text{ } ^\circ\text{C}/(\text{W} \cdot \text{mm}^2)$ and $R_{ch} = 0.025 \text{ } ^\circ\text{C}/\text{W}$ per module, the equivalent thermal resistances and coldplate requirements are calculated from (16)–(18). The cooling system can be further optimized as described in [28]; however, this is beyond the scope of this study. A liquid-cooled configuration with a coolant specific performance index (CSPI) of $40 \text{ W}/(^{\circ}\text{C} \cdot \text{L})$ is therefore assumed, yielding comparable cooling volumes for both voltage levels, as summarized in Table 6.

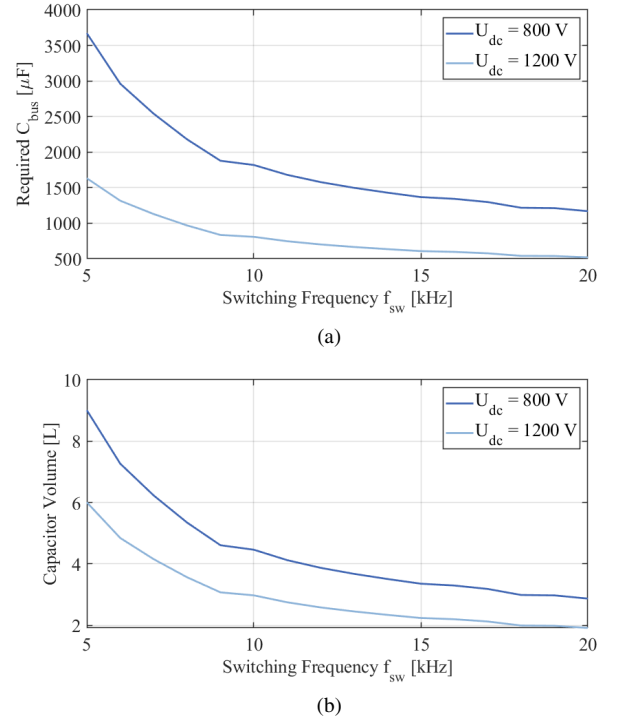


FIGURE 5. Effect of switching frequency on dc-link sizing for 800 V and 1.2 kV operation ($m_a = 1$, $\cos \varphi = 0.9$, $P = 250 \text{ kW}$). a) Required dc-link capacitance versus switching frequency. b) Estimated capacitor volume versus switching frequency.

TABLE 6. Thermal parameters and cold plate-to-ambient resistance.

Inverter	T_j ($^{\circ}\text{C}$)	T_a ($^{\circ}\text{C}$)	$R_{jc,eq}$ ($^{\circ}\text{C}/\text{W}$)	$R_{cc,eq}$ ($^{\circ}\text{C}/\text{W}$)	R_{ca} ($^{\circ}\text{C}/\text{W}$)	CSPI ($\text{W}/^{\circ}\text{C} \cdot \text{L}$)	Vol. (L)
800 V	125	25	0.0014	0.0083	0.0528	40	≈ 0.5
1.2 kV							

K. SUBSYSTEM VOLUMES AND SPECIFIC POWER DENSITY

The inverter volume is obtained by summing the contributions of the power modules, the dc-link capacitors, and the cooling system. The corresponding specific power density is expressed as

$$\rho_P = \frac{P_{\text{rated}}}{V_{\text{pm}} + V_{\text{cap}} + V_{\text{cooling}}}. \quad (21)$$

The specific power density defined in this section is based on the sum of the modeled component volumes and therefore excludes enclosure voids, integration margins, terminal spacing, and other practical packaging penalties. Table 7 summarizes the representative volume breakdown and resulting virtual-prototyping-based specific power densities. The difference in ρ_P primarily stems from the dc-link capacitor, whose volume decreases with increasing voltage level due to lower current ripple and capacitance demand. Consequently, within the adopted comparison framework, the 1.2 kV inverter achieves a higher component-sum-based power density, benefiting from reduced current stress and smaller dc-link capacitance requirements.

TABLE 7. Component Volumes and Specific Power Density.

Inverter Voltage (V)	Power Module (L)	dc-link Capacitor (L)	Cold Plate (L)	Aux. System (L)	ρ_P (kW/L)
800 V	0.5	3.5	0.5	0.5	50.0
1.2 kV	0.5	3	0.5	0.5	55.5

L. SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

While the 800 V inverter exhibits lower $r_{ds(on)}$ and switching energy per device, the higher current required for equal power output offsets these advantages. Under identical packaging, die area, and loss constraints, both voltage levels achieve comparable efficiency and thermal performance. Consequently, within the adopted equal-loss benchmarking framework, the 1.2 kV inverter achieves a higher component-sum-based power density, primarily due to reduced current stress and smaller dc-link capacitance requirements.

V. MOTOR LOSS EVALUATION

A. WINDING AND INSULATION ADAPTATION

For a fair comparison between the 800 V and 1.2 kV systems, the same motor geometry and electromagnetic design are maintained. The higher dc-link voltage is accommodated by reconnecting the existing parallel winding paths in series, while preserving the number of turns per slot and conductor dimensions. As a result, the torque constant, base speed, and magnetic loading remain unchanged, and the machine terminal voltage scales proportionally with the dc-link voltage.

This winding-reconnection discussion is intended as a controlled comparison assumption for evaluating the voltage-scaling effect, rather than as a complete machine redesign study.

B. COPPER AND CORE LOSSES

The stator copper loss is

$$P_{cu} = 3I_{rms}^2 R_s, \quad (22)$$

where R_s is the phase resistance at operating temperature. Since the same conductors are retained and the current per conductor is assumed to remain similar, the copper loss is expected to remain of comparable magnitude in first approximation. However, higher insulation requirements at 1.2 kV typically mandate thicker groundwall and turn insulation [29], which reduces the slot fill factor and slightly increases R_s , leading to a marginal rise in P_{cu} .

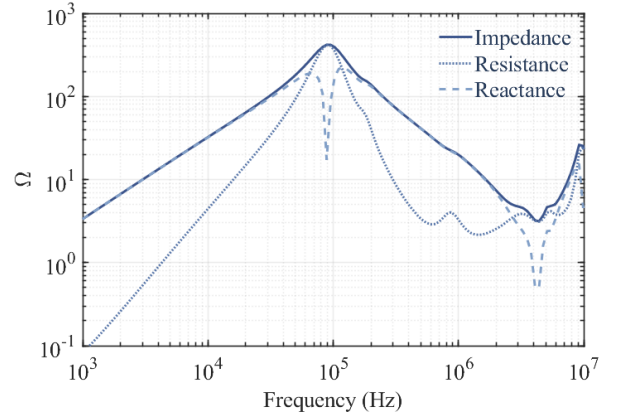
Core losses remain essentially unaffected because the electrical frequency and air-gap flux density are identical in both voltage levels:

$$P_{core} = k_h f B^2 + k_e f^2 B^2, \quad (23)$$

where k_h and k_e are the hysteresis and excess-loss coefficients. This decomposition follows standard iron-loss formulations widely used in electric-machine design [30].

C. HARMONIC-LOSS CHARACTERIZATION VIA IMPEDANCE-BASED LOSS FACTOR

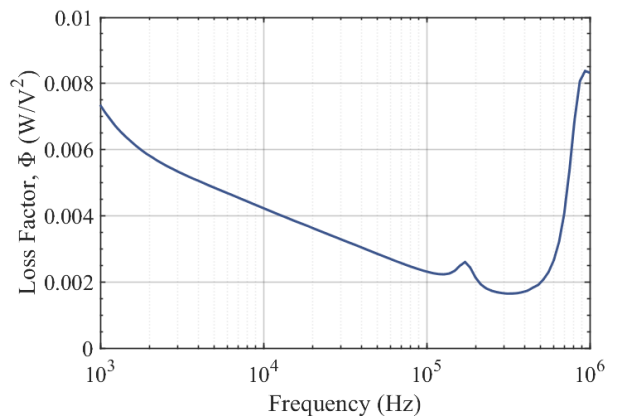
Harmonic losses are evaluated using the machine's frequency-dependent impedance $Z(j\omega)$, obtained from small-signal LCR measurements or harmonic-injection tests over the relevant carrier and sideband frequencies [31], [32]. An example of the measured magnitude and phase response is shown in Fig. 6. The measured impedance response is used here as an experimentally informed basis for the harmonic-loss assessment, while recognizing that the quantitative outcome remains dependent on the adopted scaling assumptions.

**FIGURE 6.** Measured frequency-dependent impedance $Z(j\omega)$ of the 600 V_{DC} rated machine.

From the measured impedance response, a voltage-based loss factor is extracted as

$$\Phi(\omega) = \frac{P_{add}(\omega)}{|V(\omega)|^2}, \quad (24)$$

where $P_{add}(\omega)$ denotes the incremental loss associated with a small injected voltage at frequency ω . The resulting frequency-dependent profile $\Phi(\omega)$, shown in Fig. 7, quantifies the additional loss contribution per unit squared harmonic voltage.

**FIGURE 7.** The derived loss factor $\Phi(\omega)$ versus frequency.

D. LOSS FACTOR SCALING WITH SERIES/PARALLEL RECONNECTION

Reconnecting parallel winding paths in series increases the effective phase inductance, altering the winding's high-frequency impedance behavior. Under this change, the loss factor $\Phi(\omega)$ scales with the square of the inductance ratio as given:

$$\Phi(\omega)(U_{dc,2}) = \Phi(\omega)(U_{dc,1}) \frac{U_{dc,1}^2}{U_{dc,2}^2}, \quad (25)$$

This scaling should be interpreted as an idealized first-order approximation, assuming that the dominant effect of the series/parallel reconnection is the change in effective phase inductance, while other high-frequency parasitic paths remain of secondary importance.

E. SYNTHESIS OF PWM HARMONIC LOSS

Under carrier-based sinusoidal PWM, the phase voltage can be expressed as a double-Fourier series composed of the fundamental component and carrier/sideband harmonics [27]:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{v_{ph}(t)}{V_{dc}} &= \frac{A_{00}}{2} + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} [A_{0n} \cos(n\omega_R t + \theta_R) + B_{0n} \sin(n\omega_R t + \theta_R)] \\ &+ \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} \sum_{n=-\infty}^{\infty} [A_{mn} \cos(\psi_{mn}) + B_{mn} \sin(\psi_{mn})], \end{aligned} \quad (26)$$

where ω_R and ω_C denote the fundamental and carrier angular frequencies, and $\psi_{mn} = m(\omega_C t + \theta_C) + n(\omega_R t + \theta_R)$. For fixed modulation index, the harmonic amplitudes scale linearly with the dc-link voltage.

Let $\mathcal{H}$ denote the set of dominant carrier and sideband harmonics extracted from (26). Using the loss factor $\Phi(\omega)$ of (25), the total additional harmonic loss is obtained by superposition:

$$P_{\text{harm}} = \sum_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \Phi(\omega_h) |V_h|^2, \quad (27)$$

where V_h is the phasor amplitude of the h -th voltage harmonic (e.g., obtained via the known Bessel-function coefficients for SPWM). This formulation enables a direct comparison of harmonic losses between 800 V and 1.2 kV systems by capturing both the voltage-scaling of harmonic amplitudes ($|V_h| \propto V_{dc}$) and the voltage-scaled frequency dependence of the motor loss factor $\Phi(\omega)$. Accordingly, the harmonic loss at 1.2 kV can be expressed as

$$\begin{aligned} P_{\text{harm},1200} &= \sum_{h \in \mathcal{H}} \left(\frac{800^2}{1200^2} \Phi(\omega_{h,800}) \right) \left| \frac{1200}{800} V_{h,800} \right|^2 \\ &= P_{\text{harm},800}, \end{aligned} \quad (28)$$

indicating that, under the adopted PWM assumptions and first-order reconnection scaling, the harmonic-loss contribution is predicted to remain approximately unchanged for the

two dc-link voltage levels. This result suggests that increasing the dc-link voltage does not necessarily worsen PWM-induced motor losses when the winding reconnection is properly accounted for within the present first-order framework.

F. OVERALL EFFECTS AND DESIGN IMPLICATIONS

The reconnection preserves the machine's fundamental electromagnetic characteristics, including the torque constant and base speed, but introduces a slight increase in phase resistance due to thicker insulation, resulting in a modest increase in copper losses. Core losses remain essentially unchanged. The reduced high-frequency loss factor $\Phi(\omega)$ with higher dc-link voltage leads to similar harmonic losses under identical PWM schemes. Overall, according to the adopted impedance-based first-order assessment, the 1.2 kV configuration is expected to preserve motor efficiency to a large extent, with only a slight increase in copper losses due to insulation-related resistance changes.

VI. CASE STUDY OF A 1.2 KV INVERTER: HOLISTIC EFFICIENCY OPTIMIZATION ACCOUNTING FOR MOTOR HARMONIC LOSSES

Building on the representative equal-loss benchmark introduced in Section IV, this section focuses on the selected 1.2 kV design and refines the switching-frequency choice by explicitly combining inverter losses and motor harmonic losses.

A. OPTIMIZATION FRAMEWORK

A holistic optimization procedure was conducted to identify the switching frequency range that minimizes total system losses, considering both inverter and motor contributions. The analysis was based on the Infineon FF3MR20KM1H 2 kV SiC MOSFET power module, configured with ten dies in parallel, yielding an effective die area of $\sim 300 \text{ mm}^2$ per switch. Accordingly, this section should be interpreted as a focused design study for the selected 1.2 kV realization, rather than as a universal optimization result for all 1.2 kV traction-inverter implementations. The on-state resistance and effective output capacitance values were derived from datasheet parameters, while the switching energy was treated as a controllable function of switching speed (dv/dt). The inverter losses over varying switching frequency are illustrated in Fig. 8.

B. MOTOR HARMONIC LOSSES

The motor harmonic losses are characterized experimentally using an impedance-based loss factor $\Phi(\omega)$, measured over the relevant frequency range of the traction machine for the 600 V configuration and appropriately scaled for 1.2 kV operation. The scaling applied here follows the first-order loss-factor and winding-reconnection assumptions introduced in Section V. By combining the measured $\Phi(\omega)$ with the harmonic content of the inverter output voltage, the total harmonic losses are evaluated as a function of switching frequency. A decreasing trend in harmonic losses is observed

at higher switching frequencies due to increased harmonic attenuation as illustrated in Fig. 9.

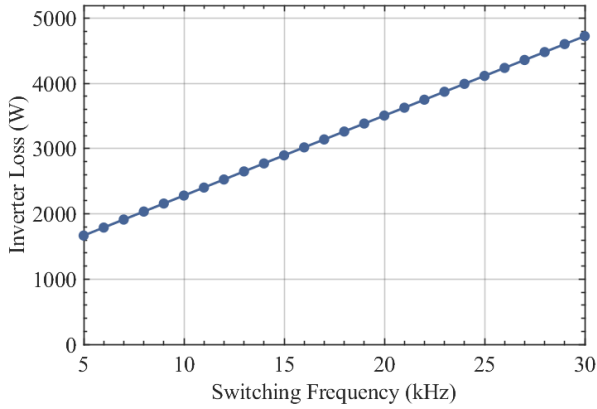


FIGURE 8. Inverter losses versus switching frequency at rated current.

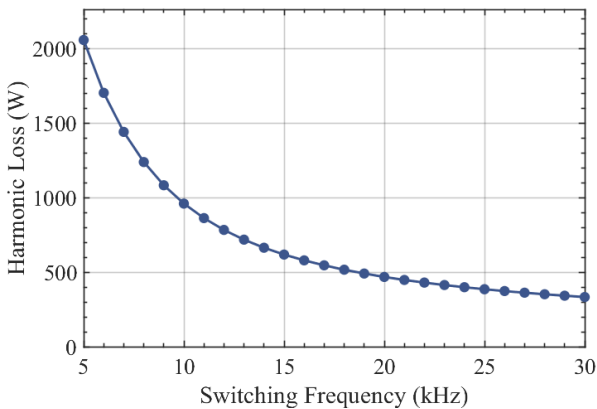


FIGURE 9. Motor harmonic losses calculated from impedance-based loss factor.

C. LOSS TRADE-OFF AND OPTIMAL SWITCHING FREQUENCY

The inverter and motor loss components were combined to determine the total system losses over varying switching frequencies. This trade-off identified an optimal operating region where inverter switching losses and motor harmonic losses balance to yield the highest overall efficiency. The analysis demonstrated that increasing f_{sw} initially reduces total losses due to decreasing harmonic currents, while beyond a threshold, the inverter switching losses dominate as shown in Fig. 10.

D. RESULTS

For the studied configuration and adopted loss models, the switching frequency that minimizes the combined inverter and motor harmonic losses is found to be approximately 10 kHz. At this operating point, the total loss reaches a minimum while remaining within the imposed thermal constraints and

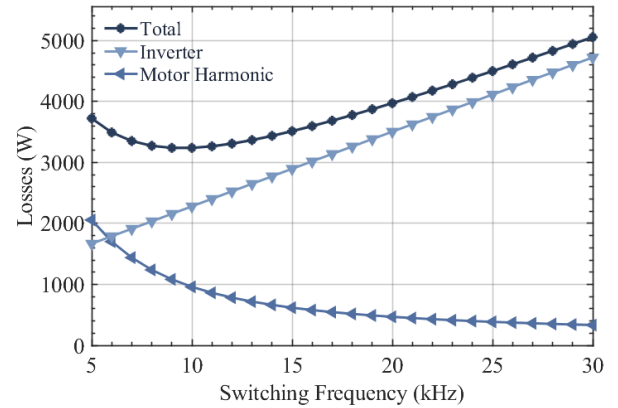


FIGURE 10. Total loss trade-off between inverter and motor as a function of switching frequency.

maintaining an acceptable contribution of motor harmonic losses.

It should be noted, however, that the loss evaluation assumes a constant junction temperature across the switching-frequency sweep. As a result, losses at lower switching frequencies may be slightly overestimated, since reduced thermal stress would lead to a lower on-state resistance $r_{ds(on)}$ and consequently lower conduction losses in practice.

VII. EXPERIMENTAL VALIDATION

This section experimentally evaluates the analytical loss-modeling approach for the selected 1.2 kV inverter design case.

A. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

A back-to-back inverter prototype was constructed to experimentally validate the proposed analytical loss calculation. The circuit diagram and corresponding photographs of the experimental setup are presented in Fig. 11 and Fig. 12, respectively.

The setup consists of two identical two-level three-phase voltage-source inverters built with Infineon FF3MR20KM1H 2 kV SiC MOSFET power modules, operating from a 1.2 kV dc-link. Both inverters are mounted on liquid-cooled cold plates with regulated coolant flow, and the system is controlled through an Imperix B-Box RCP platform implementing PWM control and real-time data acquisition. The setup includes high-voltage differential probes and isolated current sensors for monitoring dc-link voltage and phase currents. The cold-plate inlet and outlet temperatures, coolant flow rate, and total calorimetric heat dissipation are continuously measured to determine the inverter losses. Unless otherwise stated, the reported measured losses correspond to the total six-leg back-to-back arrangement under steady-state thermal conditions.

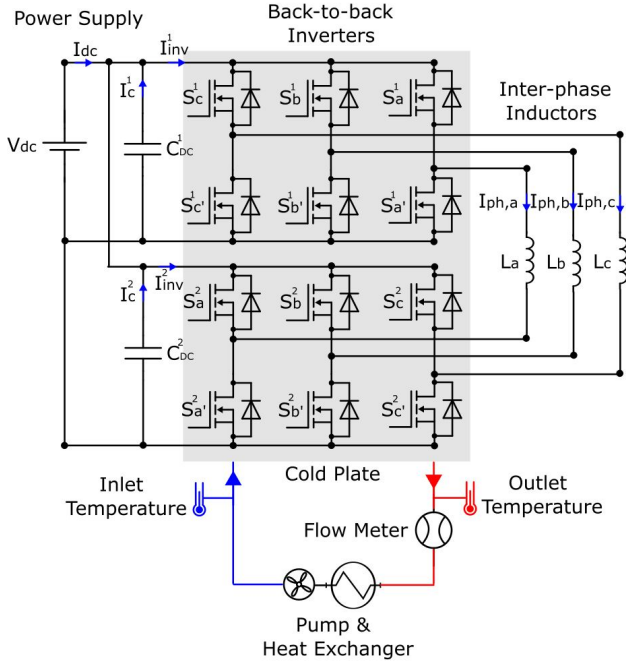


FIGURE 11. Circuit schematic of the experimental back-to-back inverter setup.

B. MEASUREMENT PROCEDURE

First, time domain waveforms of a phase voltage and phase currents were recorded to verify the rated operation of the prototype inverter, shown in Fig. 13.

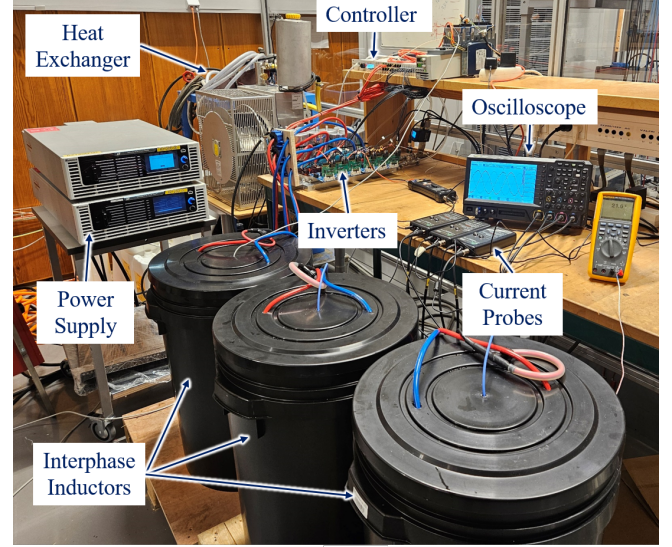
Second, efficiency measurements were conducted under steady-state thermal conditions by operating the inverter at various RMS phase currents and switching frequencies. The RMS phase current was incrementally varied from 50 A to 200 A, and the switching frequency was sampled between 7 kHz and 15 kHz. Each operating point was maintained until thermal equilibrium was reached to ensure repeatable data.

C. DATA ACQUISITION

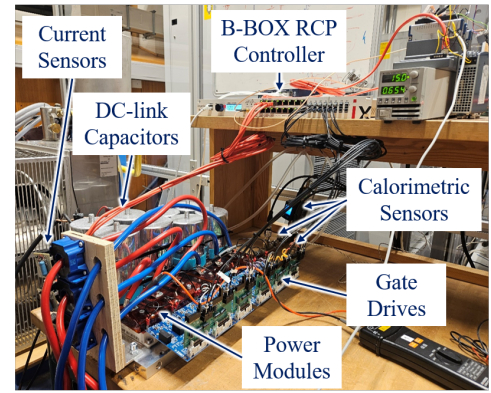
First, zero-current switching losses were measured at two different switching frequencies, as presented in Table 8. These measurements were used to identify the effective output-capacitance-related switching contribution before fitting the current-dependent switching-loss coefficients. Then, steady-state total losses and cold-plate temperatures were obtained over a range of phase currents and switching frequencies, presented in Table 9 and Table 10, respectively.

TABLE 8. Measured total loss P_{loss} (W) at $I_{RMS} = 0$ at two switching frequencies for 6-legs.

I_{RMS} (A) ↓ / f_{sw} (kHz) →	7	19
0	298.61	680.82



(a)



(b)

FIGURE 12. Experimental setup employed for validation. a) Back-to-back inverters prototype. b) Inverters under test.

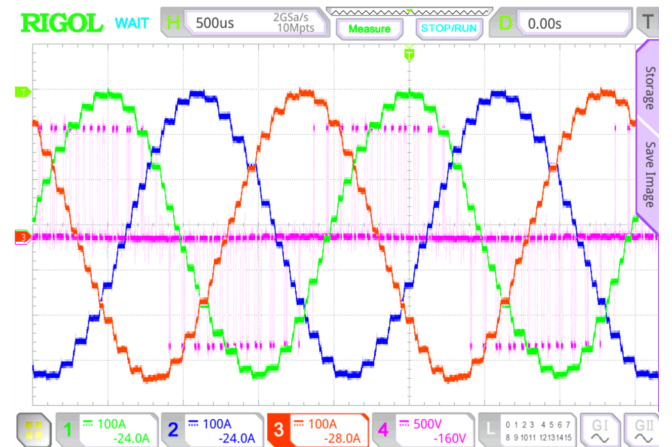


FIGURE 13. Measured a phase voltage and three-phase current waveforms under steady-state operation at $m_a = 1$, $f_{sw} = 10\text{kHz}$, $I_{ph} = 200A_{RMS}$.

TABLE 9. Measured total loss P_{loss} (W) vs. I_{RMS} and f_{sw} for 6-legs.

I_{RMS} (A) ↓ / f_{sw} (kHz) →	7	10	15	19
50	636.9	998.1	1204.5	1549.8
100	1382.9	2037.2	2398.1	3361.3
150	2307.9	2942.9	3861.7	5067.7
200	3479.5	4417.1	5948.9	7878.4

TABLE 10. Measured cold-plate temperature T_{cp} (°C) vs. I_{RMS} and f_{sw}

I_{RMS} (A) ↓ / f_{sw} (kHz) →	7	10	15	19
50	27.618	26.929	28.869	29.638
100	29.669	30.652	33.661	30.357
150	33.738	35.472	38.705	42.314
200	37.071	39.829	46.275	53.120

D. RESULTS AND INTERPRETATION

The equivalent output capacitance $C_{\text{oss,eq}}$ is identified using zero-current loss measurements. Table 11 presents the model-based decomposition of inverter losses into conduction and switching components, while the loss-model parameters $\{\alpha_1, \alpha_2\}$ are identified from the measured losses over varying current and switching frequency, as presented in Table 12.

TABLE 11. Conduction loss P_{cond} (W) (top) and switching loss P_{sw} (W) (bottom) for 6-legs.

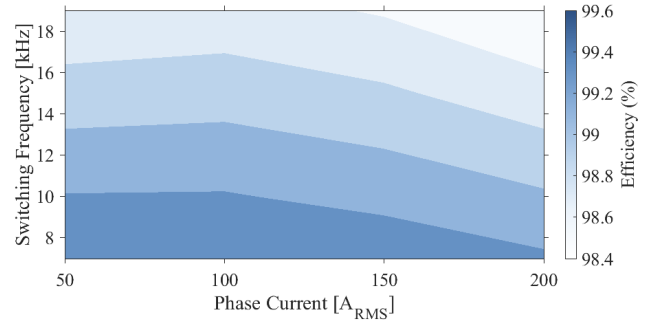
I_{RMS} (A) ↓ / f_{sw} (kHz) →	7	10	15	19
50	59.0	61.6	68.0	68.0
	563.5	805.0	1207.5	1624.3
100	275.0	296.8	341.7	341.7
	1009.7	1442.5	2163.7	2908.4
150	721.4	804.5	804.5	1064.9
	1467.4	2096.3	3004.9	3982.9
200	1498.2	1491.1	2063.3	2374.6
	1936.4	2976.6	4149.8	5256.1

TABLE 12. Switching Parameters from Measurements.

Parameter	Symbol	Identified Value
Linear current coefficient	α_1	172.1 $\mu\text{J/A}$
Quadratic current coefficient	α_2	151.2 nJ/A^2
Equivalent output capacitance	$C_{\text{oss,eq}}$	3.66 nF

Fig. 14 presents the measured inverter efficiency as a function of RMS phase current. At full-load operation ($P_{\text{out}} = 250$ kW, $V_{\text{dc}} = 1.2$ kV, $f_{\text{sw}} = 10$ kHz), the measured efficiency reaches 99.12%. Over the tested operating range, the analytical loss model predicts the measured inverter losses with an error of approximately 10%. This agreement further supports the use of the proposed virtual-prototyping framework for quantifying the conduction and switching loss com-

ponents, thereby providing a reliable basis for inverter-level efficiency optimization within the tested operating range.

**FIGURE 14.** Measured inverter efficiency along with RMS phase current and switching frequency at $V_{\text{dc}} = 1.2$ kV.

Further, the volumes of the manufactured inverter components were measured, as reported in Table 13. Two different power-density metrics are reported. The first is a component-sum-based specific power density, obtained from the sum of the measured component volumes. The second is a bounding-box-based volumetric power density, which additionally reflects practical packaging space, geometric clearances, and integration margins. The measured values show good agreement with the estimated volumes, with an average error within 11%.

TABLE 13. Component Volumes, Specific Power Density (based on the summed component volumes), and Bounding-Box-Based Volumetric Power Density for Established Inverter.

Power Module (L)	Dc-link Capacitor (L)	Cold Plate (L)	Aux. System (L)	ρ_p (kW/L)	$\rho_{v,bbbox}$ (kW/L)
0.56	3.56	0.62	0.32	49.4	20.83

As expected, the bounding-box-based volumetric power density is lower than the component-sum-based value because it includes practical unused volume associated with layout, interconnections, mounting clearances, and overall mechanical integration.

VIII. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE WORK

This study has several limitations that should be noted. First, the 800 V versus 1.2 kV comparison is not validated by two dedicated hardware prototypes, and the experimental validation is limited to the selected 1.2 kV inverter case. Second, the charging analysis is intentionally first-order and does not include detailed electrochemical charging profiles, battery thermal behavior, or charging-power tapering with state of charge. Third, the motor harmonic-loss comparison relies on an impedance-based first-order scaling approach under winding-reconnection assumptions, and therefore does not represent a complete machine redesign or full multiphysics validation. Fourth, cost, EMI, insulation aging, gate-driver dynamics over a wider switching range, and drive-cycle-

weighted system optimization remain outside the present scope.

IX. CONCLUSION

A system-level assessment of increasing the dc-link voltage from 800 V to 1.2 kV for heavy-duty electric vehicle powertrains was conducted, and the inverter-level design methodology for the selected 1.2 kV case was experimentally evaluated on a 250 kW SiC prototype. The analytical results indicate that a higher dc-link voltage can reduce current levels and improve system compactness, while the inverter-level experimental results support the feasibility of the selected 1.2 kV design approach.

Key outcomes are summarized as follows:

- Increasing the dc-link voltage from 800 V to 1.2 kV can, under the representative charging assumptions adopted in this study, reduce either cable losses or cable mass by approximately 56% and 33%, respectively, while improving compatibility with megawatt-class charging operation.
- Within the adopted equal-loss virtual-prototyping framework, the 1.2 kV inverter design exhibits thermal behavior comparable to that of the 800 V case, while achieving higher power density due primarily to the reduced dc-link capacitor volume.
- For the realized 1.2 kV prototype, the analytical loss model predicts the measured inverter losses within approximately 10% over the tested operating range, while the measured full-load efficiency reaches 99.12%.

Overall, based on the present analytical comparison and prototype-level inverter validation, increasing the dc-link voltage to 1.2 kV appears to be a practical route toward more compact, efficient, and charging-capable heavy-duty electric powertrains.

ACKNOWLEDGMENT

The authors acknowledge the use of an artificial intelligence-based language model, ChatGPT (OpenAI, GPT-5.4), for limited assistance in improving the clarity and grammar of the manuscript throughout all sections. The AI tool was not used to generate scientific content, results, interpretations, or conclusions, and all technical content and final editorial decisions remain the sole responsibility of the authors.

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